

PROPOSED METHODOLOGY — PSYCHOSOCIAL RISK ASSESSMENT, SWITCHBOARD SERVICES

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August 2026 — a worker's proposal for how the clause 7.2 assessment be conducted, offered in consultation under sections 47 to 49 of the Work Health and Safety Act 2011. Companion to the ISO 45003, and recognised practice in emergency communications settings.

Psychosocial Hazard Mapping and the Proposals for Consultation. Nothing in this document is a demand or an allegation; the method proposed is drawn from the Code of Practice 2022,

PART 1 — THE EIGHT PHASES PROPOSED

1. GOVERNANCE. An assessor independent of the functions being assessed; published terms of reference; a small steering group including an operator representative, any Health and Safety Representative, and the union. The Code of Practice 2022 and ISO 45003 stated as the methods frame.
2. THE RECORDED DATA (work as recorded). Call volumes by hour and day; emergency-code activity; the rosters audited against the fatigue rules; the team's leave usage mapped against the rosters and the demand data; turnover, vacancy and backfill data; the complaints correspondence; EAP usage; incident history; overtime.
3. THE SURVEY (work as experienced). The "People at Work" instrument — the validated, benchmarked psychosocial risk survey developed with the Queensland regulator, available without cost — offered to all operators with anonymity protected.
4. OBSERVATION (work as done). The assessor attends the room across shift types, including night and weekend shifts, and observes the work as it is actually performed — the concurrency, the interruptions, the emergency activations.
5. INTERVIEWS. An interview offered to every operator; structured prompts; and exit interviews sought from operators who have recently left the area.
6. CONVERGENCE AND RISK RATING. The data, survey, observation and interview findings triangulated; each hazard rated by duration, frequency and severity as the Code provides; the resulting risk register shared with the operators.
7. CONTROL SELECTION IN CONSULTATION. A controls workshop with the operators; controls considered in the order the Regulation requires; each adopted control given an owner and an implementation date. The Proposals for Consultation are offered as a starting set.
8. REVIEW. Implemented controls carry review dates; a small set of indicators is tracked (fatigue-rule compliance, complaint response times, leave-against-demand correlation); the survey repeated at twelve months.

PART 2 — MATTERS PROPOSED FOR INCLUSION IN SCOPE

- (a) A critical-incident debrief and peer-support step following defined trigger events (emergency codes, deaths, abusive or distressing calls), as is standard in comparable emergency communications settings.
- (b) Post-call recovery arrangements — a short off-queue recovery after distressing calls — and a defined surge protocol for periods when demand exceeds capacity.
- (c) The physical work environment of the room: headset acoustic protection, noise, console ergonomics, screen-based work breaks, and lighting.

(d) A quality-assurance framework including call-recording review, introduced in consultation and framed as protective — an objective record that resolves complaints and accusations without them resting on the operator.

(e) An evidence-based occupancy standard, so that sustained utilisation remains within recognised bounds for call-handling work.

(f) Service standards on departments for the supply of roster and contact-detail updates to the Switchboard, addressing the recurring cause of misdirected calls at its source.

(g) A documented training and competency framework for the room's functions, including any shift-supervision function.

(h) A standing, anonymous route for operators to raise hazards, with feedback guaranteed, measured at the twelve-month review.

PART 3 — CONSULTATION

I offer this methodology as an input to the scoping of the assessment, and ask that the scoping discussion address each phase and each proposed scope item, with the outcome recorded. I will attend any discussion at any time, with a support person and my union representative present.

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